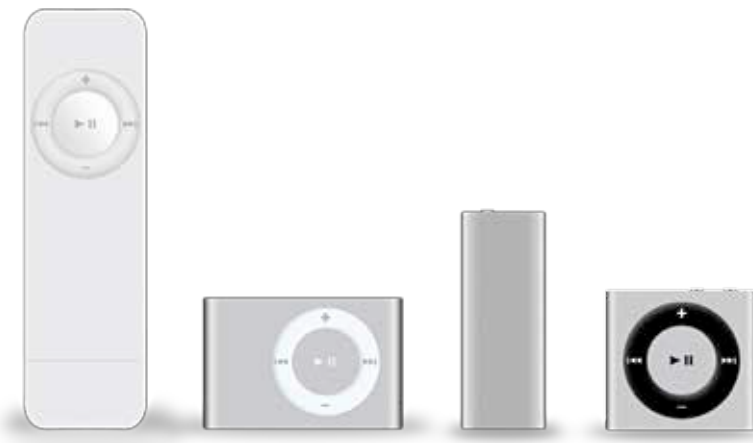


Google (or is it Alphabet?) is one of the most valuable companies in the world.

Finding stuff is one way to find your information, another is to read through an Encyclopedia. Before the internet came along, we needed to go to libraries to do research, and the rich kids would scoff at you for having to do so, because their parents had bought them the entire Encyclopaedia Britannica collection. Quiz junkies and your neighbourhood wise-asses would read up facts and look for moments to show off their big brains. Those of us (above 30) with limited access to libraries or encyclopaedias would either listen in awe, or secretly plan to strangle aforementioned wise-asses when no one was looking.



Apple's iPod shuffle was one of the best selling models

Disruptions don't always come in the form of yet another capitalist company looking to get rich... sometimes they come in the form of not-for-profit do-gooders. Wikipedia is the obvious example we're giving here, and it came along with a mission to make information easily available to everyone with access to the internet. Jimmy Wales and Larry Sanger wanted the world to be able to share knowledge with one another by making their online encyclopedia a Wiki, so that everyone could contribute. Ward Cunningham invented the WikiWikiWeb (the very first Wiki) in 1994. Wiki is a Hawaiian word that means "quick".

Wikipedia went on to become one of the largest sites in the world, and certainly the most referenced, and if you have used it to learn something new in the past few years, we suggest you donate something to them, so that they can keep it alive. It is, after all, still a nonprofit looking to do some good.

Not everyone loves Wikipedia, though, and many criticise it for having too many flaws, and too many errors and biases creeping into the content on the site because of the fact that anyone can edit the open format. Many articles do not point to reliable sources, and editors don't have the time to fix everything. Internet trolls are also known to keep causing trouble by adding in false information to quite a few pages. You certainly shouldn't depend on Wikipedia to research your college thesis, or anything like that. It's really good for pop-culture and simple explanations of scientific terms, though you should still visit the citations and sources mentioned for a proper understanding yourself. At

the very least, Wikipedia is the easiest to find collection of links to references, further reading and citations on any topic.

FORBIDDEN FRUIT

Yes, yes, we mean Apple. We're not the biggest Apple fans here at Digit, but we have to grudgingly admit that the company did cause some of the biggest disruptions over the past decade.

At a time when the world was still trying to figure out how to deal with music piracy and MP3, and just after Napster had been shut down, Steve Jobs introduced the Apple iPod to the world on 23 October, 2001. Most of the world yawned – another digital music player, and locked to the Mac platform that almost no one owns, how wonderful (that's sarcasm).

Now 2001 was the height of the PC-software development boom, so obviously there were PC workarounds available that let people connect their iPods to PCs to transfer music, but still, it was no big deal.

Apple had also launched iTunes, which was trying to get people to pay for music. Too soon, Apple, way too soon. Napster wasn't even properly buried, the MCAA was suing grandmas, and here was Apple asking you to pay, for MP3s!

Obviously, most competing MP3 player companies would have been sniggering, making fun of Steve Jobs and his iPod. What they failed to notice was that the iPod had brought something new to the table. An improved interface and a way of scrolling through hundreds of songs easily – something you really have to be good at when you offer to let users store over 2000 songs.

Then suddenly, towards the end of 2003, we start hearing about the numbers of iPods sold are now calculated in millions. By 2004 it's 2 million, then 3 million, and the world seems to be going iPod crazy. The touch-wheel scroller seems to be a huge success, and people are lapping it up. Apple also officially embraces PC users (something that we assume was a very tough compromise for Steve Jobs to accept). iTunes reports that it's "sold" 13 million songs, and the world has officially begun to get over its music-piracy fetish. Before you know it, the term "iPod" is used as common terminology for all portable media players or MP3 players, just as the brand Xerox is often used to speak of the act of photocopying.

Apple didn't stop there, however.

In the late '90s and early 2000s, smartphones were meant for business users only, and BlackBerry (then RIM) was the undisputed king of the smartphone game. Players such as Sony-Ericsson, Nokia and Motorola made up the bulk of the sales, but the pinnacle of performance phones was reserved for BlackBerry (and for a short time, Palm).

With Apple already famous for the iPod, and many rumours suggesting that an Apple phone was coming soon, there was a buzz amongst consumers, who now saw Apple as 'cool' once again. On 29 June, 2007, Apple closed all its stores in the afternoon, preparing for the 6 PM launch of the iPhone. People started lining up outside the stores, and of course, media had to show up to see what the fuss was about. Although tied solely to AT&T, the iPhone still sold like hotcakes, with many ditching their providers for AT&T just to get the shiny new iPhone.